could no longer be considered an impenetrable barrier. Commenting on the boundary that was drawn up in 1914 between Tibet and India in NEFA, Patel predicted that the Chinese were highly unlikely to honour any of the previous agreements. He went on to make some critical suggestions that included the need for a detailed appraisal of India's forces and their deployment, especially with regard to the steps that had to be taken to strengthen the northern and northeastern border; the development of roads and communication networks, including rail and air connections; the need to be able to not just move troops but also back them up with enough logistical support that could also, if necessary, support armour; re-examine India's support for the PRC's admission into the United Nations given their blatant aggression in Tibet; and, equally importantly, the need to retain not just the Indian Mission in Lhasa but also maintain the existing military posts at Gyantse and Yatung that secured the traditional trade route.

This letter was written twelve years prior to 1962. Tragically for India, the Sardar died thirty-eight days after sending the letter to Nehru. The general belief in India is that Sardar Patel's words of wisdom went to the funeral pyre with him. That, as we shall see, may not have been the case.

Nehru may have been obsessed with his own image as a champion of non-alignment, but militarily that had not stopped him from eventually taking the right steps when needed, as when Pakistan unleashed its tribal lashkars in Kashmir in October 1947. Even though Nehru made some critical mistakes—going to the UN in 1948 just when a military solution to the problem seemed feasible and then supporting China on the world stage despite it having invaded Tibet—he could not have been unaware about the importance of the country's defence.

Further, the invasion of Tibet on 7 October 1950 had belied Nehru's belief that China would not actually step across the forbidden line. 'Liberate Tibetans from whom?' he would ask whenever anyone prior to the event would suggest that China was preparing to invade Tibet to liberate the Tibetans.

Sardar Patel's letter, apart from spelling out the new ground reality, was also an indirect indictment of India's soft stand towards China on the issue. Nehru, especially sensitive to Sardar Patel's views, acted immediately. Within days of receiving the letter he ordered the setting up of the Himmatsinhji Committee (also known as the North and Northeast Border Committee) in order to survey the problem of defence and security of the